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Shah Rukh (centre) with the high-profile legal team that fought his son's case

the NCB's role in the bust. This included the agency's choice of Kiran Gosavi as key witness. Gosavi was wanted by Pune police in two cheating cases. Another NCB witness, Prabhakar Sail, later alleged that Sameer Wankhede, the agency's celebrity zonal director, had forced him to sign blank papers as a witness. Sail also alleged he had heard Gosavi asking a man named Sam D'Souza to arrange Rs 8 crore to be given to Wankhede. This allegation and a subsequent complaint saw the city police jump in to investigate Wankhede. It became another flashpoint between the Centre and the state government.

The controversy came at a peculiar time for the industry. Covid-19 and the lockdown shuttered theatres last year and, business-wise, the last two years have been Bollywood's worst on record. As viewers turned to OTT for their entertainment fix, 'character actors' like Manoj Bajpayee and Pankaj Tripathi eclipsed the Khan troika who had transfixed audiences for over two decades. The Aryan Khan case had been preceded by the Sushant Singh Rajput case, again investigated by Wankhede. If it weren't for these circumstances, it is hard to imagine the star son's arrest getting the kind of traction it did.

Within days, however, the case took a series of twists. Police investigations found Sail's allegations against Wankhede to be baseless. They did, however, find evidence of Shah Rukh Khan's secretary Pooja Dadlani preparing to pay Rs 25 lakh to Sam D'Souza—the first in a Rs 50 lakh tranche to obtain Aryan's release. The bag of cash was for Gosavi who, the police found, was lying—Wankhede had not made any such demand. D'Souza revealed details about the money transaction in a statement to the police. Interestingly, the police are yet to record the statements of Dadlani and Khan Sr regarding this transaction—one of many such loose ends in the case. Other inexplicable twists—the NCB claimed Aryan's WhatsApp chats contained talk about the drugs. The NCB first said it hadn't found any drugs on Aryan. It amended this to say that drugs of 'commercial quantities' were found on him. The agency then accused him of hatching a conspiracy to supply drugs in the city.

A week after his arrest, the sessions court denied Aryan bail. This saw members of the legal fraternity speak out. Senior lawyer Abhishek Manu Sanghvi said the NDPS Act's rehabilitative focus had been forgotten and the agency was not pursuing the big fish. "If the highly understaffed and highly overworked NCB is to run after such individual incidents, I think we have no possibility of running a good anti-drug control system in this country," he said. The Bombay High Court granted bail to Aryan and Arbaaz on October 28. The star son had by then spent close to a month in Mumbai's infamous Arthur Road prison. The NCB's case, built on specious evidence, soon unravelled in court. The HC, while stating that it had found "nothing objectionable" in Aryan's WhatsApp chats also set a vital precedent—chats on the messaging service could not be held as evidence in narcotics cases. It also pointed out that no drugs were found on him.

The controversy did not end there. State minister of minority welfare Nawab Malik launched an attack on Wankhede alleging that he had forged his birth certificate and religion. Malik submitted documents to the Mumbai Police claiming that Wankhede was a practising Muslim who had secured the IRS job under a Scheduled Caste quota (reservation is not applicable to members of the minority community). Malik also demanded that Wankhede be sacked while alleging that he owned a bar in Navi Mumbai.

The officer, it now emerges, had acquired the bar licence when he was a minor. Wankhede says the bar was owned by his father, a retired government employee, and he only held a power of attorney for it. The state excise department is now probing the case, another reason why the NCB officer needs to worry. Until this drug bust, Wankhede was a celebrated anti-drugs crusader. Last September, while investigating Sushant Singh Rajput's death, he had interrogated Bollywood celebrities like Deepika Padukone, Shraddha Kapoor and Sara Ali Khan over alleged links with drug peddlers. The personal attacks have now pushed Wankhede on the back foot.

With the controversy sullying the NCB's reputation, the agency formed a special investigation team for six cases, including the Aryan Khan case. Wankhede was unceremoniously removed as head of the investigation. His tenure with the NCB ended in December and it is likely the 2008 batch IRS officer will be transferred out of the narcotics agency. If he moves out of Mumbai, it will be in no small part due to his role in the Aryan Khan case. It will be one of many such unpredictable twists in the drugs bust case. ■